

5.5 Offline Browsers

This class of applications is useful if you have limited Net access. If you regularly visit a site, rather than go online every time you want to visit it or save every page individually on the hard disk, you can use an offline browser to do the job. Such applications visit the site and download all pages on it (it helps if the pages are linked using simple HTML), even following the links on the pages and downloading those pages too.

There is a flip side to downloading a Web site. Since ads are what keeps the site creator from pulling the plug to the site, it would be beneficial to him if you visit the site repeatedly rather than just once to download it. As a precaution, some sites do not allow non-browsers to visit the site; some are created dynamically without using proper HTML links—as in the case where your link points to something that ends like “&p=2”.

All offline browsers have the following essential features :

Mimicking

As mentioned, some sites prevent non-browsers from visiting them. So offline browsers should be able to mimic popular browsers like IE or Firefox to gain entry.

Data and Link Filtering:

Filters can be set so you do not end up downloading irrelevant content like ads, and even content from other sites. You can set filters to enable the downloading of files that are under a specific directory. Filtering is very important since it is possible that if an offline browser is set loose on a popular site that is linked to many other sites, it may end up saving the entire Net.

Incremental downloads

Web sites that have been downloaded once need not be downloaded entirely every time they need to be updated. An offline browser can find and download only those pages that have a cre-